

Product Requirements Document

SAFPA Funeral Parlour Operating System (FPOS)

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1. Overview & Executive Summary

SAFPA is entering a period where leadership, member value, policy engagement, and industry relevance matter more than ever. Publicly, SAFPA is positioning itself around collaboration, policy dialogue, growth, and strategic partnerships, and current leadership has spoken about building a SAFPA that adds value to members' businesses. This proposal is designed to turn that leadership mandate into a practical, scalable programme with measurable business impact for members.

We propose that SAFPA establish a **national member digitisation and business enablement programme** that uses the association's aggregate buying power to help funeral parlours modernise in a way that is affordable, practical, and controlled by the industry itself. The programme would provide member businesses with access to **websites, mobile apps, connectivity, premium collection, policy administration, and funeral service management tools**, supported by a SAFPA-led commercial and governance framework.

This is not simply a software rollout. It is a **sector-strengthening initiative**. It is intended to help SAFPA members collect premiums more efficiently, reduce revenue leakage, manage policies and service delivery more professionally, improve customer trust, and prepare members for a more formal and more demanding operating environment.

The proposed model recognises that SAFPA members are not all the same. Some are small community-based schemes with fewer than 100 members. Others are large, sophisticated operators with tens or hundreds of thousands of lives on book. Some are digitally mature; many are not. Some operate in metropolitan environments; others work in rural and region-specific contexts with unique cultural and operational nuances. The programme is therefore designed as a **modular, tiered platform** rather than a one-size-fits-all solution.

1.1 Why This Matters Now

The strategic case for SAFPA to lead this initiative is strong.

First, the regulatory and policy environment is moving toward greater professionalism, transparency, and consumer protection. The South African Law Reform Commission's review of laws regulating funeral parlours and related services notes that the sector is governed by multiple pieces of legislation across different departments and municipalities, proposes an ombud scheme and a code of conduct, and highlights gaps such as the lack of compulsory qualifications or statutory restrictions on who may operate as a funeral director. The draft code also emphasises transparent pricing, itemised quotations, complaints processes, protection of confidential information, and comprehensive record-keeping.

Second, the insurance and collections side of the market is under increasing scrutiny. The Insurance Act introduced a dedicated class of life insurance business for funeral policies together with a

proportionate framework for microinsurers. In its 2024/25 Regulatory Actions Report, the FSCA states that more than 70% of new cases involved unregistered financial services and insurance businesses, and it identifies unregistered insurance in the funeral parlour industry as a specific focus area, including self-underwriting and unauthorised premium collection from clients.

Third, SAFPA itself is publicly leaning into a bigger leadership role. Its 2026 convention is positioned as a platform for collaboration, policy dialogue, networking, and growth, bringing together funeral practitioners, suppliers, regulators, government leaders, and partners. This proposal gives SAFPA a concrete industry-building programme that matches that public ambition.

In short, the sector is being pulled toward higher standards. The question is whether that transition will be shaped **for the benefit of funeral parlours**, or imposed on them from outside. This proposal argues that SAFPA should lead that transition on behalf of its members.

1.2 The Strategic Opportunity for SAFPA

SAFPA has a unique advantage: **collective scale**.

Individually, many funeral parlours cannot negotiate affordable technology, payment solutions, connectivity, compliance support, or systems integration. Collectively, SAFPA can.

That means SAFPA can create a programme that does four things at once:

1. It lowers the cost of digitisation for members.
2. It improves the operating quality of member businesses.
3. It strengthens SAFPA's relevance and value proposition.
4. It gives the sector a credible, industry-owned path to formalisation and growth.

This is the central strategic proposition:

SAFPA should use its aggregate buying power to build a shared digital and commercial platform that helps member funeral parlours grow, professionalise, and compete more effectively — without giving up control of their businesses or customer relationships.

1.3 Product Name

SAFPA Funeral Parlour Operating System (FPOS)

1.4. Short Product Statement

SAFPA FPOS is a multi-tenant SaaS platform that enables funeral parlours to manage members, policies, premium collections, funeral service workflows, branches, digital presence, and reporting, while giving SAFPA structured oversight and a scalable digitisation programme for its membership.

1.5 Product Summary

SAFPA FPOS is a multi-tenant digital platform that enables SAFPA to digitise its member funeral parlours by providing a shared, scalable system for:

- member and policy administration
- premium collection and reconciliation
- funeral service and case management
- branded websites and digital presence
- reporting, support, and association-level oversight

The platform must support a wide range of funeral parlour operators, from small community schemes with roughly 50 members to larger operators managing up to 300,000+ lives, while remaining affordable, modular, and usable in low-bandwidth environments.

1.6 Purpose of This PRD

This document defines the product vision, goals, users, scope, requirements, MVP, non-functional requirements, and success criteria for the SAFPA platform. It is intended to align business, product, design, and engineering stakeholders before development begins.

2. Background and Problem Statement

SAFPA members operate in a fragmented market with widely differing levels of digital maturity, operational sophistication, and scale. Common industry problems include:

- paper-based or spreadsheet-based member and policy administration
- unreliable premium collection and weak reconciliation
- revenue leakage from missed or failed payments
- low visibility into arrears, lapse risk, and active member books
- limited digital presence and inconsistent customer engagement
- weak service workflow management during funeral operations
- poor reporting and limited readiness for formalisation or compliance

Many funeral parlours cannot afford suitable technology on their own. SAFPA seeks to use its aggregate buying power to provide members with a shared digital platform and commercially negotiated services that strengthen member businesses without taking ownership of their customers or data.

3. Product Vision

Build a SAFPA-led digital operating system for funeral parlours that improves **collections, control, and service delivery**.

The platform should become the core day-to-day business system for participating members, enabling them to manage policies, collect premiums, run funeral operations, and serve customers through digital channels.

4. Product Goals

4.1 Primary Goals

The product must help participating funeral parlours:

1. collect premiums more efficiently and reduce revenue leakage
2. manage members, dependants, and policies accurately
3. manage funeral service workflows from notification to closure
4. improve customer visibility and trust through digital presence
5. support branches, field teams, and regional operating differences
6. provide SAFPA with structured, aggregate insight into adoption and performance

4.2 Business Goals

The platform should also help SAFPA:

- improve its member value proposition
- create a sustainable commercial model for digitisation
- enable a tiered adoption path for different member sizes
- support partnerships with banks, payment providers, telcos, and other ecosystem partners

4.3 Initial Success Metrics

These are proposed launch targets and should be refined during discovery:

- 80% of pilot parlours actively using the platform weekly within 90 days of go-live
- 95% of successful premium transactions automatically reconciled on the same day
- 50% reduction in manual premium follow-up work for pilot members
- 70% of pilot funeral cases managed digitally end-to-end
- website go-live for a new parlour within 3 business days of configuration approval
- member/policy import completed within 2 business days for standard onboarding cases

5. Non-Goals

The first release is not intended to be:

- a full general ledger or accounting ERP
- a full insurance carrier core system
- a payroll or HR system
- a vehicle telematics platform
- a sophisticated actuarial engine
- a consumer marketplace for funeral comparisons

These may become future integrations or later modules, but are not part of initial scope.

6. Target Users

6.1 Primary Users

- SAFPA national administrators
- SAFPA provincial/regional administrators
- funeral parlour owners
- branch managers
- policy administrators
- collections/finance staff
- funeral operations coordinators
- field agents or sales agents

6.2 Secondary Users

- policyholders/customers
- family members interacting during a service case
- suppliers and service partners with limited task access

7. User Personas

7.1 SAFPA Programme Administrator

Needs to onboard members, track adoption, manage packages, and view aggregate reporting across participating funeral parlours.

7.2 Funeral Parlour Owner

Needs visibility into premiums, arrears, policies, branches, staff activity, funeral case status, and business performance.

7.3 Branch Manager

Needs to manage branch-level customers, staff, cases, and local reporting without seeing data outside their permission scope.

7.4 Policy Administrator

Needs to capture members, dependants, and beneficiaries, update records, track policy lifecycle events, and issue documents.

7.5 Collections Clerk

Needs to monitor due premiums, failed collections, receipts, reconciliation status, and arrears follow-up.

7.6 Funeral Operations Coordinator

Needs to manage death notices, funeral scheduling, task allocation, documents, suppliers, vehicles, and family communications.

7.7 Policyholder/Customer

Needs to view their policy, make payments, receive reminders, update details, and contact the funeral parlour easily.

8. Product Scope

8.1 Core Product Modules

The product will be structured into the following modules:

Module	Purpose	MVP
SAFPA Admin	Manage member parlours, packages, adoption, aggregate reporting	Yes
Parlour Admin	Configure tenant, branches, products, users, branding	Yes
Digital Presence	Templated websites for parlours	Yes
CRM / Lead Capture	Capture leads and convert to members	Yes
Policy & Member Management	Manage members, policies, dependants, beneficiaries	Yes
Premium Collection	Billing, collection, receipts, reconciliation, arrears	Yes
Funeral Service Management	Death notices, case workflow, scheduling, tasks	Yes
Communications	SMS/email/WhatsApp notifications	Yes, with phased channels
Reporting & Analytics	Dashboards, exports, branch and collections reporting	Yes
Customer Self-Service	Customer login, payments, profile updates	Phase 2
Offline Mobile Support	Low-bandwidth and offline capture for field use	Phase 2

9. Product Principles

The platform must be:

- **multi-tenant**
- **role-based and secure**
- **configurable by parlour and branch**
- **mobile-first where practical**
- **API-first for integrations**
- **usable in low-connectivity environments**
- **white-label capable for member branding**
- **modular so smaller parlours can start simple**
- **association-led but member-controlled**

10. Key User Journeys

10.1 Onboard a New SAFPA Member Parlour

1. SAFPA approves participation
2. system creates parlour tenant
3. branches and users are configured
4. branding and website template are selected
5. products and policy rules are configured
6. data import is completed
7. payment provider is connected
8. parlour goes live

10.2 Register a New Policyholder

1. lead is captured online, in branch, or by agent
2. member record is created
3. dependants and beneficiaries are added
4. package is selected
5. payment method is chosen
6. required documents are uploaded
7. policy becomes active based on business rules

8. welcome communication is sent

10.3 Collect Monthly Premiums

1. premium due date is reached
2. collection batch is generated
3. payment provider attempts collection
4. results are returned to platform
5. successful transactions are applied
6. failed transactions are flagged
7. arrears and reminders are updated
8. reports reflect latest status

10.4 Manage a Funeral Case

1. death notice is logged
2. policyholder is identified or new service case is opened
3. coordinator is assigned
4. documents and eligibility checks are completed
5. service tasks and dates are scheduled
6. staff, suppliers, and resources are assigned
7. family communications are logged
8. service is delivered
9. case is closed and archived

11. Functional Requirements

11.1 SAFPA Administration

- FR-001** The system must allow SAFPA to create and manage participating funeral parlours.
- FR-002** The system must allow SAFPA to assign region/province to each parlour.
- FR-003** The system must allow SAFPA to assign subscription packages or service tiers.
- FR-004** The system must provide aggregate dashboards across participating parlours.
- FR-005** The system must track adoption status, onboarding progress, and active usage by parlour.
- FR-006** SAFPA users must not have unrestricted operational access to all tenant data unless explicitly authorised by policy and permissions.
- FR-007** The system must support publication of notices, training resources, and partner services for participating members.

11.2 Parlour Administration

- FR-010** Each parlour must have its own tenant space with isolated data.
- FR-011** Each parlour must be able to create and manage multiple branches.
- FR-012** Each parlour must be able to configure branding, logo, colours, contact details, and business profile.
- FR-013** Each parlour must be able to create and manage users and assign roles.
- FR-014** Each parlour must be able to configure products, packages, and pricing.
- FR-015** Each parlour must be able to configure templates for customer communications.

11.3 Websites and Digital Presence

- FR-020** The platform must generate a branded website for each participating parlour from configurable templates.
- FR-021** The website must support custom domains or SAFPA-hosted subdomains.
- FR-022** The website must allow publication of service packages, branch details, and contact information.
- FR-023** The website must include lead capture and enquiry forms.
- FR-024** Website forms must push captured leads into the platform.
- FR-025** The website must be mobile responsive and manageable by non-technical users.

11.4 CRM and Lead Management

- FR-030** The system must capture leads from website forms, branches, and field agents.
- FR-031** The system must assign lead owners and track lead stage.
- FR-032** The system must allow conversion of a lead into a customer/member record.
- FR-033** The system must capture the source of each lead for reporting.

11.5 Policy and Member Management

- FR-040** The system must support creation and management of customer/member profiles.
- FR-041** The system must support dependants, beneficiaries, and family relationships.
- FR-042** The system must support creation of policies/plans linked to a member.
- FR-043** The system must support configurable policy/package rules, including waiting periods and status transitions.
- FR-044** The system must support the following policy states at minimum: draft, pending, active, suspended, lapsed, reinstated, cancelled, closed.

- FR-045** The system must track premium amount, billing frequency, next due date, arrears, and payment status.
- FR-046** The system must support documents linked to a member or policy.
- FR-047** The system must support bulk import of members and policies from CSV/Excel.
- FR-048** The system should support group or burial society style enrolment structures in a later MVP enhancement or phase 2.

11.6 Premium Collection and Reconciliation

- FR-050** The system must integrate with at least one payment provider in MVP.
- FR-051** The system must support multiple payment methods, including debit order, EFT, card, and manual branch capture.
- FR-052** The system must generate premium billing events based on configured schedules.
- FR-053** The system must record successful, failed, reversed, and pending payment transactions.
- FR-054** The system must automatically apply successful payments to the correct policy/account.
- FR-055** The system must generate receipts for successful payments.
- FR-056** The system must surface failed transactions for follow-up and retry.
- FR-057** The system must calculate and display arrears and overdue balances.
- FR-058** The system must support import or matching of provider settlement/reconciliation files where direct callbacks are insufficient.
- FR-059** The system must maintain a full audit trail for payment events.

11.7 Funeral Service and Case Management

- FR-060** The system must allow users to log a death notice or new funeral service request.
- FR-061** The system must support both policy-linked service cases and cash/private service cases.
- FR-062** The system must create a funeral case record with status tracking.
- FR-063** The system must allow assignment of a case owner/coordinator.
- FR-064** The system must support task checklists for service delivery.
- FR-065** The system must support scheduling of funeral-related events and milestones.
- FR-066** The system must support assignment of branch staff, vehicles, or suppliers where enabled.
- FR-067** The system must allow documents and notes to be attached to a funeral case.
- FR-068** The system must maintain a communication log per case.
- FR-069** The system must allow closure and archiving of completed cases.

11.8 Communications

- FR-070** The system must send payment reminders and receipts.
- FR-071** The system must send policy status communications.
- FR-072** The system must send funeral case updates where enabled.
- FR-073** The system must support templated messaging by parlour.
- FR-074** The system must support SMS and email in MVP.
- FR-075** WhatsApp support should be added in phase 2 or earlier if commercially critical.
- FR-076** The system must maintain delivery logs for outbound communications.

11.9 Reporting and Analytics

- FR-080** The system must provide dashboards for active members, active policies, due premiums, collected premiums, arrears, and failed payments.
- FR-081** The system must provide branch-level reporting for tenant users.
- FR-082** The system must provide funeral case volume and status reporting.

FR-083 The system must support export to CSV/Excel.

FR-084 The system must provide aggregate reporting for SAFPA without exposing more tenant detail than permitted by access rules.

FR-085 The system should support scheduled emailed reports in a later MVP enhancement or phase 2.

11.10 Document Management

FR-090 The system must support upload and storage of documents against members, policies, and funeral cases.

FR-091 The system must categorise documents by type.

FR-092 The system must enforce access permissions for documents.

FR-093 The system must store metadata including upload date, uploader, and related entity.

11.11 Onboarding and Migration

FR-100 The system must support guided onboarding for a new parlour.

FR-101 The system must support CSV/Excel template-based imports for members and policies.

FR-102 The system must validate imported data and report errors clearly.

FR-103 The system must support staged rollout by parlour or by branch.

12. Non-Functional Requirements

12.1 Security

- role-based access control is required
- tenant data isolation is required
- encryption in transit and at rest is required
- audit logging is required for sensitive actions
- admin accounts should support MFA
- secure password handling and session management are required

12.2 Privacy and Compliance

- personal data handling must support POPIA-aligned practices
- the platform must store consent and communication preference where applicable
- sensitive documents must be access-controlled
- financial and policy changes must be traceable

12.3 Performance

- standard user actions should generally complete within 2 seconds under expected load
- dashboard loads should generally complete within 5 seconds for normal data volumes
- import and reconciliation jobs may be asynchronous but must provide progress feedback

12.4 Availability

- system should target high availability during business hours
- automated backups are required
- disaster recovery procedures are required

12.5 Scalability

The solution must support:

- many funeral parlour tenants
- many branches per tenant
- millions of records over time
- tenants as small as 50 members and as large as 300,000+ members

12.6 Connectivity and Device Constraints

- primary admin experience should work well on low-cost laptops and Android devices
- public and staff workflows must be bandwidth-aware
- offline capture for selected field workflows is phase 2 unless essential to pilot success

13. Data Requirements

13.1 Core Entities

The product must support, at minimum, the following data entities:

- SAFPA organisation
- region/province
- parlour tenant
- branch
- user
- customer/member
- dependant
- beneficiary
- policy/plan
- product/package
- payment transaction
- arrears record
- funeral case
- task
- document
- lead
- communication log

13.2 Data Ownership

Each parlour remains the owner of its own customer and operating data. SAFPA receives administrative and aggregate visibility according to agreed governance and permissions.

14. Integrations

14.1 Required MVP Integrations

- at least one payment gateway or collection provider
- SMS provider
- email provider
- cloud file/document storage
- website/domain hosting support

14.2 Planned Integrations

- WhatsApp provider
- debit order provider
- accounting exports
- optional identity verification
- optional insurer or policy administration connectors

15. MVP Definition

The MVP is the smallest release that allows SAFPA to onboard participating parlours and lets a parlour manage core commercial and operational workflows digitally.

MVP Must Include

- SAFPA admin console
- parlour and branch setup
- user and role management
- templated parlour websites
- lead capture
- member and policy management
- payment scheduling and transaction recording
- receipts and arrears tracking
- funeral case creation and status tracking
- document upload
- basic notifications by SMS/email
- basic operational and management reporting
- CSV/Excel import tools

MVP Excludes

- advanced customer mobile app
- deep offline mode
- full supplier marketplace
- advanced automation rules
- enterprise-grade benchmarking
- insurer-grade claims processing

16. Phase Plan

Phase 1: MVP

Focus on association onboarding, parlour setup, policies, payments, websites, and basic funeral case workflows.

Phase 2

Add customer self-service, WhatsApp, richer funeral operations, group/stokvel structures, and selected offline support.

Phase 3

Add advanced analytics, partner marketplace, expanded integrations, and large-enterprise operational features.

17. UX Requirements

- UI must be simple enough for non-technical branch staff
- common workflows must be no more than a few steps where practical
- forms must support validation and clear error messages
- dashboard views must be role-specific
- mobile-responsive interfaces are required
- public website templates must be professional and easy to configure
- terminology should be configurable where funeral parlours use different wording

18. Assumptions

This PRD assumes:

- SAFPA will act as programme owner or sponsor
- member parlours will adopt the product in tiers
- not all parlours will require all modules on day one
- at least one payments partner can be secured for pilot
- parlour data migration will often come from Excel or manual records
- initial rollout will prioritise practicality over full sophistication

19. Risks and Mitigations

Risk 1: Low adoption by smaller parlours

Mitigation: keep MVP simple, mobile-friendly, and affordable; provide onboarding support and templates.

Risk 2: Data quality issues during migration

Mitigation: provide import templates, validations, duplicate checks, and assisted onboarding.

Risk 3: Distrust about data ownership

Mitigation: make tenant ownership and access rules explicit in contracts and product permissions.

Risk 4: Payment integration complexity

Mitigation: start with one strong provider in pilot and add abstraction for future providers.

Risk 5: Overbuilding too early

Mitigation: phase delivery and keep MVP tightly scoped around collections, policy admin, and service workflow.

20. Dependencies

- SAFPA governance and sponsorship model
- commercial agreements with payment and messaging partners
- UX and discovery workshops with representative parlours
- final policy and business rules for product packages, grace periods, and status changes
- data migration templates and onboarding process
- hosting and security decisions

21. MVP Acceptance Criteria

The MVP will be considered ready for pilot when the following are true:

1. SAFPA can create and manage participating parlours in the platform.
2. A parlour can configure its branches, users, branding, and products.
3. A parlour can import customers and policies from CSV/Excel.
4. Staff can create and update member and policy records.
5. Premium transactions can be recorded and reconciled.
6. Receipts and arrears status are visible in the system.
7. A parlour website can be published from a template.
8. Staff can capture and track funeral cases from opening to closure.
9. SMS/email communications can be sent and logged.
10. Role-based access and tenant data isolation work as designed.

22. Open Questions for Discovery

The following must be confirmed before detailed design and build:

1. Will the product support only administration and operations, or also regulated insurance-linked workflows?
2. What are the exact policy lifecycle rules, including grace periods and reinstatements?
3. Which payment providers are preferred for pilot and national rollout?
4. Does every participating parlour receive a website, or only specific subscription tiers?
5. Must customer self-service be included in MVP for pilot success?
6. How much case costing and profitability tracking is required?
7. Should group schemes and burial societies be first-class entities in MVP?
8. What reporting detail is SAFPA permitted to see by policy and contract?
9. What service levels are expected from the delivery partner?
10. Should the mobile app be shared SAFPA-branded, white-label per parlour, or both?

23. Delivery Outputs Expected from the Build Partner

The delivery partner should use this PRD to produce:

- solution architecture
- system design and data model
- implementation plan
- effort and cost estimate
- wireframes/prototypes
- sprint backlog or delivery roadmap
- testing approach
- deployment plan
- support and maintenance model

24. Closing Statement

This PRD establishes the initial product direction for the SAFPA Funeral Parlour Operating System and is intended to guide design, scoping, technical planning, and phased delivery. The platform is envisioned as a practical, scalable, and commercially sustainable solution that enables SAFPA member funeral parlours to improve collections, strengthen policy and service administration, and modernise their operations without losing control of their businesses or customer relationships.

As a working document, this PRD should be refined through stakeholder engagement, technical discovery, pilot feedback, and implementation planning. The objective is not simply to build software, but to deliver a trusted digital foundation that supports the growth, resilience, and professionalism of funeral parlours across South Africa under SAFPA's leadership.